gods and its tribal feuds. With one exception, however—it is difficult to discern actual historical events from the hymns.

The geography of the book, by contrast, is very clear. To the east, the book talks of the Ganga river and, to the west, of the Kabul river. It also shows awareness of the Himalayan mountains in the north and the seas to the south (i.e. the Arabian Sea). This is a very well defined geographical area and, interestingly, roughly coincides with the Harappan world.

Most interesting of all, the Rig Veda speaks repeatedly of a great river called the Saraswati. It is described as the greatest of rivers. Forty-five of the Rig Veda hymns shower praise on the Saraswati. No other river or geographical feature comes close in importance. The Ganga is barely mentioned twice and the Indus, although referred to as a mighty river, is not given the same reverence. In contrast, the Saraswati is called the mother of all rivers and ‘great among the great, the most impetuous of rivers’. It is even called the ‘inspirer of hymns’ suggesting that the Rig Veda was composed on its banks.

The problem is that there is no living river in modern India that fits the description. This has led some historians to argue that the Saraswati is a figment of poetic imagination. Others have tried to identify it with the Helmand river in Afghanistan. However, the Rig Veda itself describes the geographical location of the river. In the *Nadistuti Sukta* (Hymn to the Rivers), the major rivers are enumerated from east to west starting with the Ganga. The hymn clearly places the Saraswati between the Yamuna and the Sutlej. There is no room for doubt. There is only one river that could fit this description—the Ghaggar. Its river bed may be dry today but satellite and ground surveys unequivocally tell us that it was once a mighty river. It is very difficult to escape the conclusion that the Rig Vedic people and the Harappans were dealing with the same river.

There is a further twist. Unlike later texts, the Rig Veda does not mention a drying Saraswati. Instead, it mentions clearly that the Saraswati entered the sea in full flow. This would suggest that the text was composed before 2600 BC! Even more intriguingly, the Rig Veda mentions poets and compositions from an even earlier age, although their works have not